

Castles Of England And Wales: Theatres Of History [C1]

In Inghilterra e nel Galles si trovano alcuni dei castelli più imponenti al mondo, risalenti a centinaia, se non migliaia, di anni fa. Le loro caratteristiche sono testimonianze del passato: politica, guerra e strategie militari, ma anche storie familiari e vita sociale.

The castles of England and Wales are theatres of history, cultural monuments, and guardians of [heritage](#). They symbolise many centuries of political drama, military conflict, power, prestige, and [family feuds](#). They have helped to build kingdoms and defend ideologies and faiths. More recently, castles have inspired authors and filmmakers, television presenters and tourists. To find out why castles are important, Speak Up got in touch with Paul Martin Remfry, an author, historian, and internationally-recognised expert in castles. He has spent a lifetime studying medieval history, genealogy, and architecture — and telling the stories of castles and the people who once occupied them.

A WHOLE WORLD

Whether it's a child building sandcastles on the beach, tourists enjoying a sunset from ancient castle [battlements](#), or viewers watching a famous fortress on television, castles continue to captivate us. But what is it about castles that makes them such special, magical places? **Paul Remfry (English accent)**: I think it's a degree of the history, and also the fact that they are exciting. You can walk into a castle, you don't know what you're going to find. They're all totally different. And they're all so fun to explore. You've got steps to go up, [dungeons](#) to go down, [battlements](#) to walk. And then you throw the history in [on top of that](#), what's happened in these places, the people who lived there. It just makes the whole world in a castle.

GOLDEN AGE

Castles are symbolic of a time and place, and were central to the feudal system that dominated medieval England and Wales. Built by monarchs and the nobility, they were designed as [strongholds](#) to protect the [ruling](#) elite and their lands. In Britain, the golden age of medieval castle building [relied heavily upon](#) the French, especially with the arrival of the Normans in 1066. **Paul Remfry:** Really, we've got to [blame](#) the French. We've got the Norman Conquest, but twenty years before that, Edward the Confessor, he was bringing in Normans and they were building castles in the Herefordshire Marches. We've got Richard's Castle, Ewyas Harold Castle, Howton Castle. Castles were coming in before the Normans and we would have had them anyway. Clifford's Tower, a historic castle built in 13th century in York.

CONTINUATION

Castles were built in strategic locations, guarding [borders](#) and key routes, and frequently using former sites of military significance. Pevensey Castle, on the South Coast of England near Eastbourne, is one of the oldest castles in England. This was where William the Conqueror and his Norman forces first landed in 1066. But the castle William built here stood within Roman fortifications dating back to 290 [AD](#). The Romans, in turn, built their early castles, or forts, on top of other, even more ancient fortifications. **Paul Remfry:** The Romans came, they saw a good site, they built on it. And often, they built on previous prehistoric forts. You've got this continuation... Hod Hill in Dorset is a classic example of a Roman fort built into an Iron Age fort. And again, up in the north, we have the same thing. So tactics never change; a good strategic position will always be a good strategic position. Unless the river or the sea changes, which is why Pevensey lost all its importance... it became two miles [inland](#), rather than a coastal castle.

EVOLUTION

Through the centuries, castles evolved in style and design. No two castles were ever the same, every [layout](#) was unique and individual. There were traditional forms of construction, however, with the Norman castle often using a [motte-and-bailey](#) design, while other castle builders used [ringwork](#), as Remfry explains: **Paul Remfry:** A [motte-and-bailey](#) is a [mound](#) of earth, with a flat top, like an [upturned pudding bowl](#). Then the castle [keep](#) would be built on the [summit](#). And then the bailey would be a defended area around the base. Sometimes attached to it like a [figure-eight](#), sometimes surrounding it, often a mix of the two. While a [ringwork](#) would just be the defended area, the bailey, with no great [mound](#) attached. When we look at early castles in France, the [ringwork](#) is much more common than the motte. Whereas in England, the motte tends to be more common than the [ringwork](#). Although both existed simultaneously, so you have the two themes advancing side-by-side. Places

Irish Castles, Guardians Of History, Myth And Legend Dalle roccaforti alle rovine spazzate dal vento: l'Irlanda abbonda di castelli medievali, alcuni dei quali sono tra le attrazioni più affascinanti del Paese Daniel Francis , Talitha Linehan

SURVIVAL

How some castles remain standing after many centuries is often a matter of luck. Many castles were demolished by opposing armies, especially during the English Civil War (1642-1651). Stonework was removed and used in buildings nearby. Even monumental castles such as Queensborough in Kent, built by Edward III in the 1360s, [vanished](#) from view. **Paul Remfry:** Other castles which are virtually irrelevant to history have survived nearly perfectly. There's an element of [chance](#), and also an element of continuation. Somewhere like Arundel on the South Coast, which has been lived in since it was built in the 1060s, and it's still got the descendants of the original builders living in it. Half of it is open to the public, though.

DEFENCE

Castles were expensive and took time and [plenty of](#) resources to build. So what function did castles serve? Why were they actually built in the first place? Were castles essentially military structures, or did they have other purposes? **Paul Remfry:** I think the initial reason is defence. But the other reason, you need somewhere to live. Then, as a castle becomes more important, you add more and more bits to it and it becomes a real status of power. The initial castle is saying, "I'm here, I'm not going." But after that, it's growing into both a home, a fortress, and a [statement](#) of our wealth and how you're not going to move us. Then of course, you get to the English Civil War when Cromwell and the rest of Parliament says, "Yes, we are going to move you." And most of them get demolished. The interior of Arundel Castle in Arundel, West Sussex, which remains the principal seat and home of the Duke of Norfolk.

SOMETHING MISSING

Many impressive and picturesque castles across England and Wales remain open to visitors today, with massive stone walls, [battlements](#), huge towers, [moats](#), [drawbridges](#), [dungeons](#), tunnels, grand halls and [ornate carvings](#). But what is missing? What do visitors not get to see? **Paul Remfry:** The first thing I think they miss is the heart of the castle, the fact it was a home. It would have been built for the lord and his family. If it was an absentee lord, then there'd be a [constable](#) who would be [running](#) the place. Everything would be built around their needs and [keeping](#) the fortress safe would be the first major thing. And the second thing would be the religion. Most castles would have had a functioning chapel with a priest, and sometimes a [chantry](#), where they'd have been saying prayers regularly for the owning family. Of course, all of that has disappeared. It does rather leave... When I walk around even a fully rebuilt functioning castle, you do get a certain feel of [emptiness](#).

COMMUNITY

Castles signified control over a particular region and its people, and often developed into centres of commerce, administration and justice. Whole communities formed within and around the castle walls. **Paul**

Remfry: Basically, it's a small functioning village. You'd have everything you need for that to exist. You'd have [blacksmiths](#), you'd have cooks. You'd have waiters. You'd have the [steward](#) who would control everything. It's a fully functioning little ... I was going to say 'family', but they're not family, that's probably the wrong word, 'community'.

LOST CASTLES

It is believed that there were once around two thousand castles across England and Wales. Today, some of those remain in use as universities, museums, galleries and tourist attractions — as well as ancient family homes. However, around a quarter of castles have been demolished and have disappeared. For Paul Remfry, the atmospheric sites of lost castles are often the most [rewarding](#) to visit: **Paul Remfry:** There's one called Carndochan on a mountainside in the middle of nowhere in North Wales. Basically, with the eye of faith, you can see almost six feet [180cm] of walls standing in places. But it's such an enigmatic ruin and the views are superb all around. Places like that, they catch me because they're so isolated and free from modern interference.

LESSONS LEARNED

Paul Remfry first began exploring castles as a child. After more than thirty years of research, learning and guiding groups, what lessons does he feel castles can offer? **Paul Remfry:** What we do counts. These people built a castle to survive till tomorrow, and a thousand years later, some of them are still standing. You can't see what you were doing, what it would lead to. I think there's a definite element of continuation and not being able to [foresee](#) the future. If you're building a castle, you're thinking the worst,

but it hasn't [turned out](#) that badly. If you want to know more about this topic, read the article [Top 10 Castles of England and Wales](#).

Glossary

- **upturned pudding bowl** = scodella per budino capovolta
- **vanished** = scomparire
- **constable** = custode del castello
- **blame** = incolpare, ritenere responsabile
- **inland** = verso l'interno
- **layout** = disposizione
- **motte-and-bailey** = motta castrale
- **foresee** = prevedere
- **heritage** = patrimonio
- **mound** = tumulo
- **running** = amministrare
- **rewarding** = soddisfacenti
- **chance** = caso
- **statement** = dichiarazione
- **dungeons** = segrete, sotterranei
- **on top of that** = inoltre, per di più
- **ruling** = governante
- **ringwork** = mura concentriche
- **chantry** = cappella commemorativa
- **battlements** = merlature
- **borders** = confini
- **keep** = mastio (torre)
- **summit** = cima
- **plenty of** = un sacco di
- **drawbridges** = ponti levatoi
- **emptiness** = vuoto
- **blacksmiths** = fabbri
- **figure-eight** = a forma di otto
- **ornate carvings** = intagli ornamentali
- **steward** = siniscalco, amministratore
- **turned out** = risultare
- **strongholds** = fortezze
- **relied heavily upon** = basarsi su, dipendere da

- **moats** = fossati
- **family feuds** = dispute, faide familiari
- **AD** = d.C. (anno domini)